Apple Messages for Business

Brand Experience Review: Recording Guide

What to film, what to leave out, and how to make the recording good enough to be worth watching

Prepared by Messaging Advisory

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Document metadata

- document: Brand Experience Review Recording Guide
- version: 1.0
- scope: video capture for a brand experience review. The process is in Document 1, the design standards in Document 2, the test cases in Document 3.
- audience: the client and MSP teams who will hold the phone and press record
- used at: Steps 4 and 5 of the process

What this document is, and is not

This is a **brand** experience review document. Its audience is Apple, assessing whether **this brand's experience** is good enough for a real customer. It is not the MSP integration review, and the difference is not cosmetic.

The integration review asks whether a platform can do everything, for any brand it onboards. It is answered by breadth: show every feature, show every variant, populate every optional field, because a field the platform cannot fill is a capability gap. In that document an empty field is a failure.

The brand review asks whether **your customer has a good time**. It is answered by depth: pick the journeys that matter to your business, build them properly, and film them as a real person would live them. Here a feature you do not need is not a bonus. It is padding, and it reads on camera as a demonstration rather than an experience, which is the impression you least want to leave.

So the three rules that shape everything below:

1. **You do not need to use every element.** Use what the task genuinely needs.
2. **You do not need to showcase everything.** Coverage is not the goal.

3. **Focus on the use case, then demonstrate that use case.** One journey done beautifully beats six done thinly.

There is one boundary on rule one. Apple fails "text only experiences that do not leverage platform features". No single feature is mandatory, but using none of them fails. The mandatory thing is the category, not any item in it. A well built journey with a Quick Reply, a List Picker and a Rich Link is complete. Ideally a form, a time picker or a map would complete the journey, and an App Clip or an App Extension will end it on a high note. The same journey in prose is not.

Choosing what to film

Almost every Apple Messages for Business brand use case is one of five shapes. Find yours, and the table tells you what the journey is made of and which extension blocks it usually picks up.

Archetype	The customer wants to	Typically uses but not limited to	Often adds
Find and choose	Browse options and pick one	Quick Reply triage, List Picker with images, Rich Link	Apple Pay, Wallet pass, App Clip
Book and manage	Reserve, move or cancel a slot, or deliver something	Quick Reply, Time Picker, Rich Link confirmation	Authentication, Maps payload, Form
Check and resolve	Find out what happened and fix it	Quick Reply triage, Rich Link, attachments	Authentication, escalation, Form
Enrol and receive	Sign up and be kept informed	Quick Reply, Form, opt in	Business Invitations, Wallet pass
Reach a person	Talk to someone who can decide	Quick Reply triage, escalation	Form for details, callback path

For some brands the real journey is a combination of them, for example find, choose and then manage.

Pick **one primary archetype** for the main recording. If your brand genuinely has two very different journeys, film the second as a short additional take rather than stretching one flow to cover both.

A test before you commit. Say your use case out loud in one sentence, from the customer's point of view, with no product names in it. "I want to move my delivery to Saturday." "I want to know why my bill went up." "I want to book a fitting." If you cannot say it in one sentence, you have picked a category rather than a use case, and the recording will wander.

Demo guidelines

These apply to every brand recording. They mirror how the video is reviewed.

- **Use a real device.** Film on a physical iPhone, not a simulator and not a sandbox, so the experience looks like what a customer would see. iOS 26 as the primary device.
- **Use QuickTime.** Connect the device and record through QuickTime mirroring, or use direct iOS screen recording. Native resolution, no edits. If you need a second take, submit the second take in full rather than stitching two together.
- **One continuous take.** Start at the entry point and run through to Leave Conversation. A cut invites the question of what happened in the gap.
- **Film the customer's screen.** The default point of view is the person holding the phone. Backend logs are not shown. The one exception is Flow B, where the live agent sequence is filmed side by side.
- **Side by side where a person is involved.** Agent console on one side, customer device on the other, both legible at the size the reviewer will watch, so typing indicators are visible in both directions.
- **Typing indicators everywhere.** A short indicator before every outbound message, including back to back messages with no customer input between them, from the live agent as well as the automation. About one second for automated messages. This is the single item most often missed on film by builds that do it correctly in production.
- **Frame every rich element with a preceding agent bubble.** A short text message immediately before every List Picker, Time Picker, Form, Quick Reply, Rich Link, Authentication card and Apple Pay request. First line a clear title, second line a short call to action. Long text never goes inside the element, where it is cropped and the customer decides without reading it.
- **Confirm back after every tap.** When the customer selects, submits or completes anything, the next message says in plain language what they just chose, before the conversation moves on.
- **Iconography.** Have brand iconography ready for every rich element you use, with a fallback image where a specific one does not exist. A missing image is more visible on camera than anywhere else.
- **Gate every personal data request.** Before asking for personal information, a clarifying yes or no question, and collect only on a yes.
- **Clean the thread before the final take.** Delete every rehearsal conversation. A thread list full of prior attempts is visible in shot and reads as an unstable build.
- **Check what else is on screen.** Notifications, other conversations, the device name, internal tooling. Anything in frame is submitted.
- **Timestamps.** Attach a timestamp list of each demonstrated item alongside the video.

Prohibited wording

Never on screen and never in the presenter's narration:

- "This conversation has been closed"
- "Finish conversation"

- "iMessage" as the name of the channel
- "Apple Business" as the name of the channel
- "iMessage app" as the name of an App Extension
- "Messaging rates may apply"
- "Data rates may apply"

Naming convention. Use "Apple Messages for Business" wherever it fits. "Apple Messages" is the approved alternative where the full name does not fit a label. Where an interface shows an unknown contact, use "Apple Messages contact", never "Apple Business Contact". The naming rule governs the console, the narration and the templates, not only the message copy.

Where the recording goes

Send the videos and the timestamp index to Messaging Advisory. We review them against Documents 2 and 3 and test the live experience on real devices ourselves before anything goes forward. Apple reviews the recording, gives feedback, and a live session usually follows.

Ideally, Messaging Advisory has access to the test experience before the video is recorded, so we can give direct and proactive feedback before you commit resources to filming.

What separates a good recording from a complete one

Completeness gets you through. This section is what makes the difference between a reviewer ticking boxes and a reviewer wanting to use your brand. It has no equivalent in the integration review, because nobody cares whether the experience feels real. Here it is the entire point.

Use real content, not placeholder content. Real product names, real prices, a plausible order number, photographs rather than grey boxes. "Product 1" and "Lorem ipsum" tell a reviewer the experience has never been used by anyone.

Give the customer a reason. Decide before you film who this person is and why they are messaging today. A customer with a motive behaves differently from a hand tapping through a script, and it shows in the pacing.

Let the customer read. Pause where a person would pause. Instant taps on a List Picker the moment it renders look like automation testing automation. A beat before the choice is more convincing than any amount of polish.

Write like a person. Short bubbles, two or three lines. Proper casing throughout. Match the customer's register without abandoning the brand's. Ask questions and behave in ways that genuinely challenge intent recognition, for example sending several messages at once, so Apple sees how the assistant gets past that rather than only how it handles the easy path.

Show the thread being useful, not being clever. A feature that appears because the flow needs it lands well. The same feature appearing because it was on a list lands badly, and reviewers can tell the difference easily.

Do not narrate the obvious. If you talk over the video, say what the customer is trying to achieve, not what the reviewer can already see. And remember the naming rules apply to speech.

End it properly. The close is the part teams rehearse least and reviewers remember most. Offer further help, confirm the outcome, and let the customer end the conversation.

How to read the flows

Actors

- **User, also called end user on device.** The person on the device. Sends messages, taps interactive elements, and controls when the conversation ends.
- **Agent (bot).** The automated assistant on the business side. It always identifies itself as automated and never implies a person is present when one is not. It can be an AI or a traditional chatbot.
- **Human agent.** A live person on the business side, reachable through escalation. From the moment of handoff the User is talking to a real person, and the conversation is presented that way.

Notation

- **Step.** A numbered move in the conversation. Steps run in order and form one continuous take.
- **Side by side.** The conversation is rendered twice, the end user on device on one side and the business side on the other, so both perspectives and both typing indicators are visible at once.
- **What it shows.** A short note on what each step demonstrates, written so it stays true for any brand.
- **[BRACKETS].** Replace with your own.

Flow A. The use case, end to end

This is the spine. It holds for all five archetypes. What changes between them is which extension blocks you drop in at Step 5, and nothing else. One continuous take, customer side, from entry point to close.

Step 1. Entry point

User: starts the conversation from a real entry point, for example a QR code, a website button, an app or an email link.

Agent (bot): receives the routing context carried by the entry point, and the conversation lands in the right flow.

If the entry point carries intent, film a second entry point that carries a different intent and show it landing somewhere visibly different. That is more convincing than any explanation.

What it shows: the entry point works, and routing is real rather than decorative.

Step 2. Greeting, disclosure and scope

Agent (bot): a short typing indicator, then a greeting inside 5 seconds that states plainly it is automated, gives the assistant's name, and says what kind of experience this is and what it can help the customer with. Not "what can I help you with?" but "I'm an automated agent and I can help you with ...".

User: knows who they are talking to and what is on offer before sharing anything.

To be clear: disclosure alone is not enough. "I am `[NAME]`, here to help with `[A]`, `[B]` and `[C]`" is the pattern. A bot that discloses and then asks "what can we help you with?" leaves the customer no wiser.

What it shows: honest automation, prompt response, and a scope the customer can act on.

Step 3. The opening choice

Agent (bot): where the entry point did not already tell you the intent, offer a Quick Reply of up to five real top intents, most common first.

User: taps one, or writes their intent in their own words.

Two things to get right. If the customer has already written a clear intent, answer it rather than overriding it with the menu. And if an AI layer handles triage instead of a fixed menu, show it doing better than a menu would, since that is the only thing that justifies replacing one.

What it shows: a guided opening drawn from real demand, and an assistant that listens.

Step 4. Confirm what you already know

Agent (bot): reflects back the context it holds, for example the order, the store, the booking, rather than asking for it again.

User: is not asked to repeat anything.

What it shows: the conversation uses what it was given.

Step 5. The task

This is where the archetype takes over, and where your extension blocks go. Two to four steps, no more. Each rich element is preceded by a framing bubble and followed by a confirmation of what the customer chose.

Whatever the task, it should be visibly the thing the customer came for, and it should complete.

What it shows: the use case actually working, with platform features used because the task needed them.

Step 6. Resolution

Agent (bot): states the outcome plainly. What has been booked, ordered, changed, answered or sent, and what happens next.

User: can see the thing they wanted has happened.

A conversation that stops without confirming an outcome reads as abandoned, even when the task succeeded.

What it shows: the customer leaves knowing where they stand.

Step 7. Anything else

Agent (bot): asks whether there is anything else, as a Quick Reply so a single tap answers it.

What it shows: the close is offered rather than imposed.

Step 8. Leave Conversation and the post close block

User: ends the conversation using Leave Conversation.

Business side: attempts to send, on camera, and is blocked.

Show the blocked attempt. Do not assert it. This is one of the five points and one of the most common reasons a recording comes back.

What it shows: the customer controls the end of the conversation, and the block is real.

Flow B. When a person is needed

Filmed side by side, console and device. This is a second take, and it can start from the same entry point.

Step 1. The customer asks for a person

User: signals it, both ways if you can: once with a trigger word such as AGENT, and once with free text such as "this isn't helping" or "can I talk to someone".

Agent (bot): classifies both, and errs toward escalating. A missed escalation is worse than an extra one.

What it shows: escalation intent is detected from words and from meaning.

Step 2. Collect what the agent will need

Agent (bot): gathers the essentials before routing, so the customer is not asked again on the other side.

What it shows: the handoff respects the customer's time.

Step 3. Announce the handoff

Agent (bot): says a person is joining, and why. Where the response is not immediate, gives an estimated wait, with queue position if you have one.

What it shows: nobody is left guessing.

Step 4. The person arrives

Human agent: joins, introduces themselves by name, and picks up the thread without asking the customer to repeat anything.

User: sees the typing indicator while the agent composes, and a real exchange follows.

Type it live. A scripted paste looks like a scripted paste.

What it shows: a real person, presented as a person, on a console that is not slowing them down.

Step 5. Close

Human agent: confirms the outcome and offers further help. The customer ends the conversation, and both bot and agent are blocked from sending afterwards.

What it shows: the same close discipline applies to people as to automation.

Where a live connection is not available. Film the agreed alternative instead: the in conversation message offered first, with a stated response window, then callback or email after. Collect details in channel. The acknowledgement states specifically what happens next and when. "A team member will call you within two business hours" passes. "Someone will be in touch" does not.

Flow C. When conditions are not ideal

Short, and it can be one take. This is what proves the experience holds up outside the happy path.

Part 1. Out of hours

User: reaches the brand outside stated business hours and asks for a person.

Agent (bot): states the hours, says when a reply will come, and offers to take a message **inside the conversation** as the first option.

User: leaves the message. Film that.

Never pretend a person is available. Callback and email are alternatives offered after the in conversation message, not instead of it.

What it shows: honest handling when nobody is there.

Part 2. Capability aware fallback

User: on a second, more limited device, a Mac or an iOS 18 device, runs the same use case.

Agent (bot): swaps the unsupported element for a supported alternative at send time, and the journey continues to completion.

Two things must be visible: the swap happening, and the fallback path still finishing the task. Describing this in narration does not count. Apple wants to see that a fallback exists, and it is on the brand to demonstrate it.

What it shows: a real customer base with mixed devices is safe on this experience.

Extension library

Drop these into Flow A, Step 5, only where the use case genuinely uses them. Each is written to stand alone. If your journey does not need one, leaving it out is the correct choice, not a gap.

Rich Link. Every URL renders as a Rich Link with an image that reflects the destination page, never a bare URL and never a "tap to load" text link. Preview asset is a PNG at 240 by 240, up to 200 kB. Logo style images stay under 150 pixels wide.

List Picker. Frame it, then send it. Rows carry a thumbnail and a subtitle, not a title alone. The card itself carries its own image, which is a separate rule from the row thumbnails and the one most often missed. Show the variants your use case actually has rather than all of them.

Quick Reply. Two to five options, most common first. Use it for any bounded question rather than forcing typed text. The summary text left in the transcript afterwards is a short label, not a repeat of the question.

Time Picker. Multiple slots, and where the appointment happens somewhere, a populated location so the venue and map pin render inside the picker and travel to the calendar. State the time zone. Show the customer adding it to their calendar.

Form. Only for structured intake of several fields. For one or two fields, a plain conversational exchange is preferred. Give it a splash screen with an image, a title, an introductory description and a review page at the end of the final section. Mark sensitive responses private. Have a fallback ready for devices below iOS 18.4.

Authentication. A framing message before the card, for example "Please log into your account so I can pull up your order". Inline OAuth 2.0 with Password AutoFill. Use it before returning any order detail, account data or balance. No brand image on the card, since it renders with Apple's own iconography.

Apple Pay. Framing message first, then the sheet showing line items, payment methods and delivery options. Confirm back what the customer selected. No brand image on the sheet. Never request card details in the thread.

Attachments and Wallet pass. Send and receive the types your use case needs, and make sure they are legible on screen. A Wallet pass is worth showing where the journey naturally produces one, a ticket, a booking or a pass, and the customer adds it on camera.

Construct Payload, Maps. Where you share a location, send it as a Maps payload rather than a plain address, so the customer gets a map preview and can navigate.

Construct Payload, Apple Music. Build the storefront URL from the locale on the incoming message rather than hardcoding a country.

Construct Payload, App Clip. Where a task genuinely continues better outside the thread, an App Clip opens it without an install.

App Extension. A custom mini experience inside the thread. Worth it only where the interaction is too complex for the standard elements, for example a rich catalogue or a configurator. Call it an App Extension on camera, never an iMessage app.

Tapbacks. If a customer reacts to a message, acknowledge it. Reactions arrive as ordinary messages and cannot be threaded to a specific bubble, so acknowledge in context rather than claiming precision you do not have.

Shared location. A customer can share their location from the compose bar. Acknowledge it, reflect back the resolved place, and let them correct it before anything is dispatched on it. Never let it land in silence.

Business Invitations. Where the journey starts from an invitation, show the acceptance and then the message that follows it, explaining plainly what the customer signed up for, the category, a realistic frequency, and how to stop.

Notification enrolment. Opt in is an active tap, never inferred, and the moment of consent states how to opt out. Film the enrolment message carrying its own opt out instruction.

Multilingual. Language follows the device locale. Never open by asking the customer which language they want. If a different language is detected, confirm with a Quick Reply before switching.

Two proposed walkthroughs

Both are hypothetical and fully generic. They exist to show how the same spine produces two very different recordings.

Walkthrough one. Book and manage

`[BRAND]` is a service business. The customer wants to move an existing appointment.

1. **Entry point.** Taps the Messages button on the booking confirmation page. Intent carries "I want to amend a booking".
2. **Greeting.** "Hi, I'm `[NAME]`, `[BRAND]`'s automated assistant. I can help with bookings, changes and cancellations."
3. **Opening choice.** Skipped. The entry point already carried the intent.
4. **Confirm context.** "I can see your appointment on `[DATE]` at `[LOCATION]`. Is that the one you'd like to change?" Quick Reply, yes or no.
5. **The task.** Authentication before showing booking detail. Framing bubble, then a Time Picker with the real available slots and the venue location populated. Customer picks one, adds it to their calendar. Confirmation states the new time.
6. **Resolution.** "You're moved to `[NEW TIME]` at `[LOCATION]`. I've sent the updated confirmation." Rich Link to the booking page. Maps payload for the venue.
7. **Anything else.** Quick Reply.
8. **Close.** Customer leaves the conversation. Send attempt blocked on camera.

Extensions used: Authentication, Time Picker, Rich Link, Maps. Extensions deliberately not used: Apple Pay, Form, App Extension, Wallet pass. Nothing is lost by their absence.

Nice to have: locale detection, so the language follows the device.

Walkthrough two. Check and resolve

`[BRAND]` is a consumer business. The customer has a problem with something they received.

1. **Entry point.** Scans a QR code on the packaging. Intent carries "order issue".
2. **Greeting.** Discloses automation, names its scope.
3. **Opening choice.** Quick Reply: damaged, wrong item, missing item, something else.
4. **Confirm context.** "I can see order `[NUMBER]`, delivered `[DATE]`."
5. **The task.** Customer sends a photograph of the problem. The assistant acknowledges what it received. Framing bubble, then a List Picker of resolution options with images, replacement, refund or a call back. Customer chooses. Confirmation states the choice.
6. **Resolution.** "A replacement is on its way, arriving `[DATE]`." Rich Link to tracking.
7. **Anything else.** Quick Reply. Customer says yes, and asks something the assistant cannot classify. It apologises, re offers options including a route to a person, and the customer declines.

8. **Close.** Customer leaves the conversation. Send attempt blocked on camera.

Extensions used: attachments, List Picker, Rich Link. Extensions deliberately not used: Authentication, Apple Pay, Time Picker, Form. This journey is shorter than walkthrough one and is not worse for it.

The five points checked every time

Whatever the brand, these five are the most common reasons a recording is sent back. All five must be visible somewhere across the three flows.

- **Reachable escalation.** A live agent connection is reached, or the agreed alternative is offered and acknowledged with a specific commitment.
- **Honest automation.** The automation identifies itself as automated and never implies a person is present when one is not.
- **Leave Conversation respected.** The close is honoured, and a send attempt afterwards is shown being blocked.
- **Capability aware fallback.** The swap to a supported alternative happens at send time, on device, and the journey still completes.
- **Clean language.** None of the prohibited wording appears on screen or in narration.

The timestamp index

Submit a timestamp list alongside the videos. One line per demonstrated item: the video, the time, and what it shows.

```
V1  00:04   Entry point, QR code, intent carried into the flow
V1  00:11   Greeting, automated disclosure, assistant scope
V1  00:20   Quick Reply, four real top intents
V1  00:48   Context confirmed, no repeat question
V1  01:15   Framing bubble, then List Picker with row thumbnails and card image
V1  01:44   Choice confirmed back in plain language
V1  02:30   Resolution stated, Rich Link with page image
V1  02:52   Anything else, as a Quick Reply
V1  03:10   Leave Conversation, blocked send attempt shown
V2  00:34   Escalation by free text
V2  00:51   Handoff announced, wait time given
V2  01:20   Agent joins, introduces themselves, types live
V3  00:08   Out of hours notice, message left in conversation
V3  01:02   Fallback swap at send time on a limited device
V3  01:30   Fallback path completes the task
```

If you filled in the Evidence column of Document 3 while testing, this list already exists. Export it.

Why recordings come back

In rough order of how often we see each one.

1. A typing indicator missing on a back to back sequence
2. The rich card filmed without its own image, showing only the row thumbnails
3. Leave Conversation asserted rather than demonstrated, with no blocked send on screen
4. A bare URL or a "tap to load" link visible in the thread
5. Capability fallback described in narration instead of filmed
6. Placeholder content, grey boxes and "Product 1" in shot
7. Rehearsal threads visible in the conversation list
8. Restricted platform wording spoken in the voiceover
9. Out of hours filmed as a generic greeting rather than as a live agent request outside hours
10. Features included because they were on a list, making the whole thing read as a demo

Before you press record

- ☐ The use case is one sentence, from the customer's point of view
- ☐ Document 3 has been run in full and the in scope rows pass
- ☐ Content is real: real products, real prices, plausible names and numbers
- ☐ Brand iconography is in place for every rich element used, with fallbacks
- ☐ Filming on a physical iPhone through QuickTime, native resolution
- ☐ A second, more limited device is on hand for Flow C
- ☐ Out of hours can be triggered, or the schedule has been adjusted for the take
- ☐ Rehearsal and test threads deleted
- ☐ Notifications silenced and nothing unintended is in frame
- ☐ Side by side capture set up and both panes legible for Flow B
- ☐ Typing indicators confirmed on every outbound payload, both directions
- ☐ Every rich element has its framing bubble and its confirmation reply
- ☐ Narration script checked against the naming rules
- ☐ The timestamp index is open and ready to fill as you film

Provenance

- Apple, Pass the Experience Review v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Conversation Design Standards v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Messages for Business Use Cases form
- Messaging Advisory, Video Review Flow Instructions generic v6.6, adapted from platform scope to brand scope
- Messaging Advisory, Conversation Design Standards and Best Practices v2.1

- Messaging Advisory field observations from prior brand submissions